GB MAXIBASKETBALL F50+

DEFENSIVE HANDBOOK

DEFENSIVE PHILOSOPHY 2026

"HEART, HUSTLE & HEAVY DISRUPTION"

WHO WE ARE DEFENSIVELY

DEFENCE IS NOT A REACTION. IT IS A STATEMENT.

We are a Defensively Resilient team. That is a Golden Thread of this programme. We make opponents uncomfortable on every possession, every trip, every play phase.

> ***"We do not gamble. We do not reach. We do not give up easy touches in the Decision Box. We suffocate — as a unit, intelligently, together."***

Our defence is built on heart and hustle first, and technical excellence second. **Lazy defence is not acceptable on this team.**

MATHS BATTLE TEAM

WIN THE REBOUND

Finish every possession. One shot and done.

WIN POSSESSION

Force mistakes. Protect the ball. Value every trip.

DEFENCE STARTS OFFENCE

Every stop is the first pass of our next play.

CORE DEFENSIVE PILLARS

1 THE FOUNDATION

STANCE · VISION · TALK · ACTIVE HANDS

> *"You cannot defend what you are not ready for — whether you have the ball or not."*

- **STANCE:** Get low. Sit in the chair. Feet active. This is your athletic readiness to fight for space. No exceptions.
- **VISION:** See ball & player simultaneously. Anticipate, don't react. Gain that half-second advantage.
- **TALK:** Non-negotiable. Call matchups, screens, help. 5 voices = 1 unit. If you aren't talking, you aren't defending.
- **ACTIVE HANDS:** Disrupt passing lanes. Scoop and dig on the ball. Hands high on every close-out.

2 TRANSITION DEFENCE

CONTEST THE OUTLET · CHANNEL · HOME

> *"The game is won or lost in the moments between offence and defence. We do not give those moments away."*

- **CONTEST:** Start defence on the offensive glass. Commit 3 to rebound. Disrupt the outlet pass to kill fast breaks early.
- **NO DEAD SPACE:** We do not gamble between foul lines. No reaching or lunging. False hustle creates 5-on-4s.
- **CHANNEL:** Pick up early. Force the ball-handler to the sideline. No middle drives allowed.
- **HOME:** The first defender back protects the rim. Sprint, don't jog. Make opponents earn every touch.

CORE DEFENSIVE PILLARS

3 HALF-COURT DEFENCE

SHRINK THE FLOOR

> *"We are not five individuals. We are one connected unit — a bag that shrinks."*

- **JUMP TO BALL:** Move on flight of pass. Half-second discipline creates position.
- **10 EYES:** Connect to ball & player. Inside foot to midpoint shortening help distance.
- **NO NEGATIVE STEPS:** Move lead foot first. Eliminate false steps that allow penetration.
- **RELIABILITY:** Correct spots. Timely rotations. No freelancing in man or zone.

4 ON-BALL DEFENCE

CONTAIN · DISRUPT

> *"Nose in the middle of the chest. Pressure with feet and angles. Make everything hard."*

- **CONTAIN FIRST:** Stay in front. No easy Decision Box touches. Belly-up, mirror the ball.
- **FEET & ANGLES:** Pressure with feet, never hands alone. No reaching. No lunging.
- **IN / UP / OFF:** Manage pressure intensity based on context without stopping play.
- **HAVE AN ACT:** Use scoop and fake dig. Disrupt the ball-handler without fouling.

CORE DEFENSIVE PILLARS

5 OFF-BALL DEFENCE

HELP · STUNT · RECOVER · ECHO

> *"Connected off-ball. Locked in. Ready to act before the act is needed."*

- **HELP:** Weak-side help is early. If the ball attacks the box, you are already positioned—not arriving late.
- **JAM / STUNT:** Stop penetration. Fake help to freeze the ball, then recover. Disrupt without breaking shape.
- **TAG:** Physical contact with rollers/cutters. Slow them down, bump them, then recover.
- **ECHO CALLS:** When pressure hits the ball, communication intensifies behind it. Align behind the pressure.

6 DEFENDING SCREENS

TALK · STAY · SWITCH · HEDGE

> *"The screen only works if we let it. We talk early. We take it away before it happens."*

- **TALK:** Early communication nullifies the action. Call screens the instant you see them.
- **STAY / SWITCH:** Fight over the top or switch cleanly. No hesitation.
- **HEDGE:** On post screens, step out hard. Force retreat. All 5 protect the basket.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

If you are guarding a shooter, you must **NEVER GO UNDER** the screen — regardless of whether you are STAYING or SWITCHING. Going under gives a shooter time and space. That is not an option.

7 PROTECTING HOME / THE DECISION BOX

BOX · GANG REBOUND

> *"The Decision Box is ours. They do not live there. And a stop means nothing without the rebound."*

PHASE 1: STOP & SECURE SPACE

- **RIM PRESENCE:** Bigs take away space. Opponents hesitate before entering. Contest with verticality—stay out of foul trouble, but be felt.
- **WALL UP:** No soft touches inside. Physical, body-on-body. No leaning or reaching. We compete through contact.
- **NO STRONG-SIDE CORNER HELP:** The corner 3 is a high-percentage shot. The corner defender stays home; the rest shrink to protect the Box.
- **ACTIVE HANDS ON CLOSE-OUTS:** Arrive under control, chop feet, hands high. Contest every catch. Do not fly by.

PHASE 2: FINISH THE POSSESSION

- **BOX OUT:** Make contact before you go for the rebound. Body-on-body. Swim or spin to seal your player. Contact first, pursuit second.
- **GANG REBOUND:** All five players have a responsibility. Hunt inside position. 75% of rebounds come from the weak side—be there.
- **NEXT-PLAY FOCUS (NBA):** The moment we secure the ball: PUSH. Transition offence starts with the secure. No pause. Only the Next Best Action.

OUR SEVEN DEFENSIVE NON-NEGOTIABLES

#	NON-NEGOTIABLE STANDARD	VERBAL CALL
1	**STANCE at all times** — point of attack, once away, help-side	STANCE
2	**Talk and echo every trip** — matchups, screens, tags, calls	TALK / ECHO
3	**Contest the outlet** — clean the glass below the foul line	CONTEST
4	**No defending in dead space** — no gambling between the lines	CHANNEL / HOME
5	**Contain first** — pressure with feet; no reaching, no gambling	CONTAIN
6	**Talk screens early** — never go under on shooters	TALK / STAY / SWITCH
7	**Box out before rebounding** — finish every possession	BOX

"These are not guidelines. These are the standards we hold each other to."

THE LANGUAGE WE USE

SHARED DEFENSIVE GLOSSARY

TERM	MEANING
STANCE	Athletic ready position — low, feet active, weight forward.
VISION	See ball and player simultaneously; anticipate the play.
TALK	Constant communication — matchups, screens, tags, coverages.
ECHO	Repeat defensive calls so the unit stays aligned behind pressure.
ACTIVE HANDS	Hands always working — tracking, scooping, faking the dig.
SCOOP	Subtle upward motion from underneath ball; disrupt without fouling.
FAKE THE DIG	Threaten the steal to freeze the ball-handler; disrupt only.
BALL / CHANNEL	Pick up and channel the ball in transition; push to sideline.
HOME	Protect the basket — the #1 transition defence priority.
DEAD SPACE	Area between foul lines — we do not gamble for steals here.
CONTEST OUTLET	Disrupt outlet pass by committing to offensive rebounding.
CONTAIN	Stay in front; pressure with feet and angles, not hands.
IN / UP / OFF	Three on-ball pressure levels — shifts the whole unit together.

TERM	MEANING
JAM	Hard show on a middle drive; take away penetration.
STUNT	Fake help to freeze the ball-handler; recover without committing.
TAG	Physical contact with roll player/cutter; slow them, then recover.
DENY / BUMP	Front cuts; make contact with cutters entering Decision Box.
HELP / DROP	Weak-side baseline help on drives; protect the corner.
STAY	Fight over the screen and remain with your player.
SWITCH	Clean exchange of defensive matchups on screen — call immediately.
HEDGE	Hard step out by screener's defender; force ball-handler retreat.
DECISION BOX	The paint / lane — we protect this above all else in half-court.
BOX	Make contact before rebounding — seal, then go get the ball.
NEXT-PLAY FOCUS	Reset immediately after any play — no dwelling; Next Best Action.
FALSE HUSTLE	Reaching, gambling, fouling — looks like effort, costs the team.
FLICK THE SWITCH	Reset, adapt, and turn the tide — our response to adversity.

ZONE DEFENCE PHILOSOPHY

> *"We do not rest in a zone. We are more active, more vocal, and more disruptive in zone than in man. Zone is not a retreat—it is a different form of attack."*

CORE ZONE PRINCIPLES

- **GUARD THE AREA:** Own your space. Do not get pulled out of position by fakes. Stay home until the ball moves.
- **ACTIVE HANDS:** Hands are up in passing lanes at all times. Make the zone look crowded. Deflect passes. Shrink the court.
- **NO UNCHALLENGED CUTS:** If an offensive player cuts through your area, BUMP them. Disrupt their timing. Do not let them run free.
- **NEXT-PASS DENIAL:** Anticipate where the ball is going. Cheat towards the next pass while maintaining your area responsibility.
- **TALK EARLY:** Call cutters, call screens, call ball location. The zone must move as one connected unit. Silence kills zones.

REQUIRED EMPHASIS POINTS

ZONE SHIFTS: The entire zone shifts on the flight of the ball. We arrive as the ball arrives, not after. Move together on a string.

MATCH UP OUT OF MOVEMENT: If the offense overloads or breaks our shape, communicate and match up. Do not guard grass while they score.

FINISH WITH BOX: The biggest weakness of a zone is rebounding responsibility. Find a body. Hit a body. Go get the ball. Mandatory.

THE STANDARD DOES NOT CHANGE. ONLY THE SHAPE.

ZONE SELECTION & PRESSURE

2-3 ZONE
PROTECT THE PAINT

- **Purpose:** Force outside shots. Pack the paint against strong drivers or dominant post players.
- **Execution:** Guards must rebound long. Bottom 3 stay wide to cover corners but collapse on any post entry.
- **Weakness Management:** Vulnerable at high post/nail. Guards must drop to dig; wings must stunt up.

3-2 / 1-2-2 ZONE
PERIMETER PRESSURE

- **Purpose:** Disrupt outside shooting teams. Create turnover opportunities with active passing lanes.
- **Execution:** Top defender chases ball. Wings deny wings. Bottom defenders must sprint corner-to-corner.
- **Weakness Management:** Vulnerable in corners and deep post. Requires high energy from bottom two players.

52 ZONE PRESS
HEAVY DISRUPTION

- **Priority:** Slow the ball. Force high, looping passes. Create chaos in the backcourt.
- **Trap Zones:** Trap immediately on in-bounds in coffin corners. Trap just over half-court sideline.
- **Interceptors:** Weak-side defenders must read eyes and flight of ball. Go get it.

NON-NEGOTIABLE:
NO MIDDLE. NO COMFORT.
Keep the ball on the sideline.

"We choose our defence based on what disrupts THEM most, not what is easiest for US."

DEFENSIVE PLAY CALLS

// A shared language allows us to react faster than the offense can think. When the call is made, the role is set.

CALL	SYSTEM	ALIGNMENT / NOTE
1	HALF COURT MAN	Standard man-to-man defence. Pack line principles. No middle.
51	FULL COURT MAN	Pressure man-to-man full court. Pick up at free throw line extended.
52	FULL COURT ZONE PRESS	Aggressive trapping press. 1-2-1-1 alignment. Trap the corners.
2	2-3 ZONE	Protect the paint. Bigs stay home. Guards pressure the perimeter.
3	3-2 / 1-2-2 ZONE	Perimeter pressure. Match up on shooters. Disrupt passing lanes.

CLARITY OF CALL = CLARITY OF ROLE

THE MINDSET BEHIND IT ALL

We are a defensively resilient programme. That is not a phrase — it is a standard.
Opponents will have their runs. We will face adversity. In those moments, we flick the switch. We learn. We adapt. We turn the tide.

We never take a backward step. Every possession. Every play phase. We compete.

"THE TOUGHEST TEAM WE SHOULD EVER FACE IS OURSELVES."

HEART. HUSTLE. HEAVY DISRUPTION. **TOGETHER.** 🏀